Aurangzeb, who would make many more overtures to the orthodox factions of Islam, the duty of a ruler, as he stated in a letter to Rana Raj Singh of Mewar in 1658, was to ensure ‘that men belonging to various communities and different religions should live in the vale of peace and pass their days in prosperity and no one should interfere in the affairs of another’.

That Aurangzeb had to make this appeal to garner support reflects how deeply evocative the supra-religious theory of sovereignty was in the Mughal governing class. Opposition to the reimposition of the jiziya was based on the tenacious idea of the Mughal emperor as ruler of both Hindus and Muslims, the duhu deen ko sahib, which Akbar had so openly embodied. But if these ideals proved resilient, then the Mughal Empire itself began to crumble, in the way of all empires. After the death of the last of the Great Mughals, Aurangzeb, a number of weak rulers came to power while regional players and zamindars like the Rohilla Afghans, the Marathas, and the Nawabs of Awadh grew militarized, powerful, and loyal only to themselves.

In this chaotic and uncertain environment, with no powerful central authority, the European trading companies saw an opportunity to entrench themselves. By the early seventeenth century, the Dutch East India company (1602) joined the EIC, followed by the Danish (1616) and French (1664) overseas trading companies, initially conducting trade purely on Mughal terms. But as competition between the European companies over Indian textiles grew more fierce, they became militarized, training their own sepoy-armies which were then co-opted by regional powers in exchange for revenue-collection rights which were slowly ceded to the Europeans. The French and the English eventually got locked in skirmishes, and then deadly battles over trading rights, mirroring the Anglo–French wars that were taking place at the other end of the world. Finally, by 1757, the French had been summarily outmanoeuvred, the true rapacious ambitions of the EIC were exposed at the Battle of Plassey, and a new empire proudly unfurled its colours on the embers of the Mughal one.

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As we have seen in this book, Akbar was an extraordinary monarch in many ways. He was a military leader of genius, an exceptional judge of men and character, a builder of cities, a connoisseur and patron of art, an innovator, a man of reason and ideas, and much more. But perhaps the secret of his enduring appeal, that which made him ‘the Great Mughal’, and one of only